

73 Solomon

The king who asked God for wisdom, built the temple, and let his heart be turned away.

Solomon, son of David and Bathsheba, was Israel's third king. Early in his reign God appeared to him in a dream and said, "Ask what I shall give thee." Solomon asked for an understanding heart, and God gave him wisdom, along with riches and honor. He became famous for his wisdom, proverbs and wealth, and built the temple David had longed to build. Israel lived in peace and plenty. But Solomon married many foreign wives, and in his old age they turned his heart toward other gods. A great beginning does not guarantee a faithful ending.

At a glance

Name	Hebrew <i>Shelomoh</i> , related to <i>shalom</i> , "peace"; also Jedidiah
Family	Son of David and Bathsheba; father of Rehoboam
Reign	c. 970–931 BC, forty years over all Israel (1 Kings 11:42)
Great work	The temple in Jerusalem, begun c. 966 BC (1 Kings 6:1)
Key places	Jerusalem, Gibeon, Gihon, Ezion-geber
Key people	Nathan, Adonijah, Hiram of Tyre, the Queen of Sheba, Jeroboam
Writings	Named in Proverbs, Song of Solomon, Psalms 72 and 127
New Testament	Matthew 1:6–7; 6:29; 12:42; Acts 7:47

"Give therefore thy servant an understanding heart to judge thy people, that I may discern between good and bad: for who is able to judge this thy so great a people?"

1 Kings 3:9, KJV

The life of Solomon

Dates are approximate (BC). His age at crowning is not given; Rehoboam was 41 when Solomon died (1 Kings 14:21).

In Jerusalem	●	Born and named After David and Bathsheba's first child dies, Solomon is born. "The LORD loved him," and Nathan brings the name Jedidiah. <i>2 Samuel 12:24-25</i>
c. 970 BC	●	Anointed and secures the throne When Adonijah claims the throne, Solomon is anointed at Gihon. After David dies, he executes Adonijah and Joab and banishes Abiathar. <i>1 Kings 1:5-2:46</i>
Early reign	●	Asks for wisdom At Gibeon God says, "Ask what I shall give thee." Solomon asks for an understanding heart, and God adds riches and honor. <i>1 Kings 3:4-15</i>
c. 966 BC 4th year	●	Begins the temple In the 480th year after the Exodus, he begins the house of the LORD on Mount Moriah. <i>1 Kings 5:1-6:1; 2 Chronicles 3:1</i>
c. 959 BC 11th year	●	Temple dedicated After seven years the temple is finished. The glory cloud fills the house, and Solomon prays before all Israel. <i>1 Kings 6:37-38; 8:1-66</i>
Later years	●	His heart turns "When Solomon was old," his many wives turn his heart after other gods, and God says the kingdom will be torn from his son. <i>1 Kings 11:1-13</i>
c. 931 BC 40th year	●	Dies Adversaries rise, including Jeroboam. Solomon dies after forty years and is buried in the city of David. <i>1 Kings 11:14-43</i>

Key activities

Christians have long linked Solomon with Ecclesiastes, which is written by "the Preacher, the son of David, king in Jerusalem" (Ecclesiastes 1:1) but does not name him. Many scholars think a later writer wrote it in Solomon's voice. Views also differ on how much of Proverbs and the Song of Solomon he wrote himself.

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- 1 Loved the LORD.** He walked in the statutes of David, "only he sacrificed and burnt incense in high places." *1 Kings 3:3*

 - 2 Asked for wisdom, not riches.** God was pleased that he did not ask for long life, wealth or his enemies' lives. *1 Kings 3:5-14*

 - 3 Judged between two mothers.** He called for a sword to divide a baby, and the true mother gave up her claim to save the child. *1 Kings 3:16-28*

 - 4 Spoke wisely and ruled in peace.** He spoke three thousand proverbs, and Israel dwelt safely, "every man under his vine and under his fig tree." *1 Kings 4:25, 29-34*

 - 5 Built the temple.** It was built of stone prepared at the quarry, so no hammer or axe was heard at the site. *1 Kings 6:1-38*

 - 6 Prayed at the dedication.** "Behold, the heaven and heaven of heavens cannot contain thee; how much less this house that I have builded?" *1 Kings 8:22-53*

 - 7 Received a warning.** God appeared a second time, promising blessing for obedience and ruin for turning away. *1 Kings 9:1-9*

 - 8 Built great wealth.** He built ships at Ezion-geber, brought gold from Ophir, and answered the Queen of Sheba's hard questions. *1 Kings 9:26-10:29*

 - 9 Built altars for foreign gods.** For his wives he built high places for Chemosh and Molech on the hill facing Jerusalem. *1 Kings 11:4-8*

Across Scripture

Direct references come first. Thematic echoes are study connections, not places where the text names Solomon.

Old Testament

1 Kings 1–11; 2 Chronicles 1–9	The two main accounts of his reign
1 Chronicles 22:6–10	A son, "a man of rest," will build the temple
Proverbs 1:1; 25:1	Proverbs credited to him; Hezekiah's men copied some
Nehemiah 13:26	"Even him did outlandish women cause to sin"
Echo: Deuteronomy 17:16–17	A king must not multiply horses, wives or gold

New Testament

Matthew 1:6–7	In the line from David to Jesus
Matthew 6:29	"Even Solomon in all his glory was not arrayed like one of these"
Matthew 12:42	"A greater than Solomon is here"
Acts 7:47–48	Solomon built a house, but God dwells not in temples

For discussion

1. *Observe:* What did Solomon ask for at Gibeon, and what did God give him (1 Kings 3:5–14)?
2. *Understand:* Solomon was wise, yet his heart turned. How is being wise different from staying faithful?
3. *Apply:* Solomon's heart turned slowly. What small compromise could lead you where you do not want to go?
4. *Apply:* If God said to you, "Ask what I shall give thee," what would you ask for, and why?